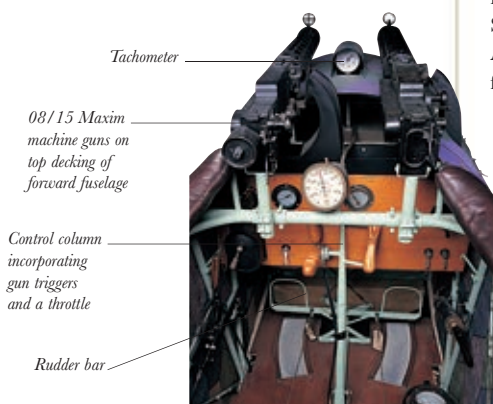


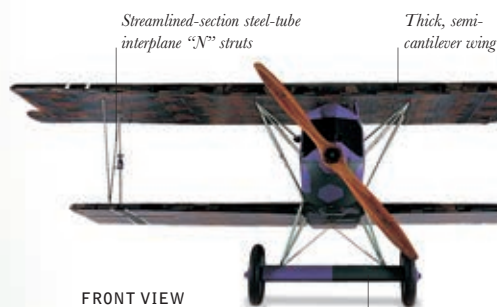
Specifications

ENGINE	185hp BMW III six-cylinder water-cooled inline
WINGSPAN	29ft 3in (8.9m)
LENGTH	23ft (7m)
HEIGHT	9ft 2in (2.75m)
TOP SPEED	116.6mph (186.5kph)
ARMAMENT	2 x 7.92-mm 08/15 Maxim machine guns

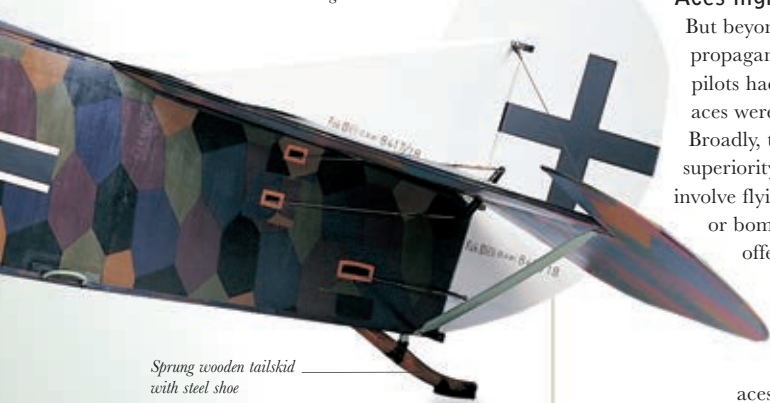


EASY FLIER

The Fokker D.VII was considered a fairly easy aircraft to fly – an important consideration, since, by the summer of 1918, pilots were being rushed to the front after a bare minimum of training.



Airfoil-shaped lifting surface encloses undercarriage axle



picturesque nature, is very likely to attract the wrong class of men." No doubt the author of the report would have included among "the wrong class of men" the courageous American volunteers who fought for France in the famous Lafayette Squadron.

Lafayette Squadron

It was in April 1916 that the French allowed New Englander Norman Prince to group seven American pilots into a high-profile squadron, reasoning that this might encourage the United States to enter the war on the Allies' side. The American volunteers earned a deserved reputation for high living and rough partying. But thrown into the thick of the fighting at Verdun in June 1916, they flew four or five patrols a day, until all seven original pilots were either dead or wounded. The Lafayette Squadron continued in existence, never numbering more than 20 members, with fresh entrants drawn from the hundreds of other American volunteers serving with more mundane French air units.

Almost a year after the US entered the war, the Lafayette Squadron was integrated into the US Army Air Service – with a sharp warning that discipline would have to be tightened. Other American pilots serving with the French were also invited to transfer to US units. An exception was African-American flier Eugene "Jacques" Bullard. Blacks were not accepted as pilots in the US force.

Despite their late arrival in the war, some Air Service pilots were enthusiastic in the pursuit of ace status. The most successful, Eddie Rickenbacker (a former "pupil" of Lufbery's), lent himself tirelessly to the demands of celebrity and publicity, even staging a fake dogfight for the movie cameras while the war was still on – a stunt that nearly turned sour when French pilots unaware of the filming tried to join in the fight.

Aces high

But beyond all the flim-flam of propaganda and publicity, fighter pilots had a real job to do, and the aces were the pilots who did it best. Broadly, the job was to win air superiority. At different times this might involve flying escort to reconnaissance or bomber missions; carrying out offensive patrols to challenge the enemy's forces; or picking off enemy reconnaissance aircraft or bombers. It was in the last of these roles that aces amassed most of their

ANTHONY FOKKER



FRIEND OF ACES

Fokker was a pilot before he became an airplane maker. He got along well with German aces, who often called the shots in decisions over aircraft procurement.

BORN INTO A WEALTHY DUTCH family in Kediri, Java, Anthony Fokker (1890–1939) was caught up in the prewar flying craze. He learned to fly in 1910 and soon designed his first mono-plane, setting up a factory at Schwerin in Germany in 1912. The war made his fortune. Wily and ambitious, he formed close ties with German bureaucrats and ace pilots alike. Orders flooded in for aircraft such as the Eindecker E.III and the D.VII.

Fokker had a pilot's feel for airplanes and a businessman's ability to organize large-scale production, but he was not an innovative designer. The Fokker trademark welded steel-tube frame was, in fact, dreamed up by his chief technician, Reinhold Platz. At the war's end, Fokker moved to the Netherlands, smuggling airframes, engines, and parts across the border. He produced successful civil and military aircraft in the postwar period, moving to the US, where he headed the Fokker Aircraft Corporation.

victories. The many qualities that made a successful fighter pilot included keen eyesight, fine reflexes, and perfect coordination; dedication to the task in hand, including a meticulous attention to the detailed preparation of their machine and guns; cool nerve when under fire; and utter ruthlessness in executing a kill. Air combat was about winning, not about giving the other side a fair chance. British ace James McCudden wrote that "the correct way to wage war is to down as many as possible of the enemy at the least risk, expense, and casualties to one's own side."